Vertical Force and Gravity

A Companion to This Lesson

Explored through the lens of

The Vertical Self

The Physics Lens

What This Booklet Is

You've just done this lesson — on the floor, in a class, or from a recording. This booklet is your companion afterward. It won't teach you the movements (you've already done them). Instead, it helps you understand what was happening underneath: why the teacher chose those movements in that order, what your nervous system was sorting out, and what to notice next time.

Each Feldenkrais lesson is a carefully designed puzzle for your nervous system. The movements aren't exercises — they're questions. This booklet helps you see what questions were being asked, and what your body was discovering.

Where You Started

> *Lying on the back, legs long and slightly apart, arms at the sides with palms facing down.*

This starting position isn't arbitrary. It's chosen to give your nervous system a baseline — a clear sense of how things are *before* the lesson begins. You'll return to it at the end, and the contrast is often striking.

The Question This Lesson Asks

Every Feldenkrais lesson poses a question to your nervous system. Not a question you answer with words — a question you answer with movement, sensation, and gradually shifting organization.

> *How can the skeleton act as a coherent column to transmit force from the floor to the crown without muscular interference?*

Cortical noise is reduced by shifting from slow, intentional pushes to rapid, light vibrations that bypass the Muscular Hoister's control. The complexity of the diagonal and breathing variations further distracts the Striver, allowing the Vertical One to emerge.

How Feldenkrais Lessons Work

To make sense of the journey through this lesson, it helps to understand three ideas. They'll come up throughout the booklet.

The Striver

When you first try a movement, there's a part of you that grips, pushes, and forces. This is your voluntary muscular effort — we'll call it the **Striver**. It means well, but it's noisy. It uses ten muscles when two would do. It holds your breath. It treats every movement as a task to be conquered.

The Foundation

Underneath the Striver, your skeleton and reflexes already know how to support you. This deeper system — the **Foundation** — is quiet, efficient, and reflexive. It responds to gravity, finds balance, and transmits force through bone rather than muscle. The lesson's job is to let the Foundation emerge.

The Washing

The lesson doesn't fight the Striver. It *washes* it away — through repetition, variation, and gentle complexity. Like water over stone, the unnecessary effort gradually dissolves. You don't try to relax. You simply repeat and vary until the Striver runs out of strategies and the Foundation is all that remains.

Three States

As you move through a lesson, you typically pass through three states:

Domination	The Striver is in charge. You're "doing" the movement with voluntary effort.
Negotiation	An active exchange. The Striver is losing its grip. You're exploring, confused in a good way.
Integration	The Foundation takes over. Movement becomes easy, quiet, almost involuntary.

The Journey

Here's what happened in this lesson, section by section. For each part, you'll see what you did and what was happening underneath.

Part 1: Initial Vertical Oscillation

Establishing the basic vertical push/pull from the feet while lying on the back, focusing on skeletal force transmission.

WHAT YOU DID

1. Scan your contact with the floor, noting islands of support and areas of tension or lifting.
2. Turn palms down and bring arms close to the body, sensing the effect on the shoulders and chest.
3. Bend knees and stand feet at hip-width.
4. Press feet into the floor to direct pressure vertically toward the crown of the head, then release.
5. Alternate pushing with the feet and pulling with traction to create a slow vertical oscillation.
6. Observe breathing and shoulder blade movement during the oscillation; imagine the spine as a turtle neck.
7. Make the oscillation faster and lighter, softening tissues to allow the force to travel through.
8. Pause and rest as you are.
9. Emphasize the pull, dragging the pelvis toward the heels, then push back up slowly.
10. Lengthen legs and rest. return to start

> *A functional goal — connecting this movement to something you actually do in life.*
>
> *Noticing how parts of your body are connected — how one movement ripples through.*
>
> *A moment of sensing — turning attention inward to feel what's actually happening.*

WHAT WAS HAPPENING

Domination

The question being posed: Can I feel the floor's pressure travel through my bones to my head?

The functional goal: Initial mapping of the vertical axis and identification of skeletal gaps.

> THE PERSON INSIDE
>
> *I am lying here sensing where I touch the floor. As I push with my feet, I feel a wave of pressure trying to reach my head, but it gets stuck in my lower back. I am trying to find the line that connects my heels to the top of my skull.*

> THE STRIVER
>
> *The Muscular Hoister is tensing the lower back and neck, trying to 'pull' the body upward instead of letting the floor push it.*

Part 2: Heel and Arm Integration

Extending the legs to use the heels for the vertical drive, assisted by the arms.

WHAT YOU DID

1. Widen legs and push/pull the body using the heels by flexing and extending the ankles.
2. Assist the heel movement by pushing and pulling the floor with the palms and arms.
3. Pause and rest. return to start

A functional goal — connecting this movement to something you actually do in life.

Noticing how parts of your body are connected — how one movement ripples through.

A pause to let things settle. Integration happens in the quiet moments.

WHAT WAS HAPPENING

Negotiation

The question being posed: How do the heels and palms clarify the vertical drive?

The functional goal: Increased leverage for longitudinal force through distal clarity.

THE PERSON INSIDE

My heels are digging in now, and my palms are helping. The force feels sharper and more direct. I can feel my whole skeleton sliding up and down the floor like a single piece of wood.

THE STRIVER

The Striver is tensing the shoulders to 'help' the arms, but the rhythm is starting to soften the grip.

Part 3: Diagonal Force Vectors

Exploring asymmetrical force transmission through diagonal configurations of limbs.

WHAT YOU DID

1. Stand one foot and place the diagonal arm overhead on the floor.
2. Push and pull with the standing foot, observing the diagonal force vector through the body.
3. Direct the force specifically toward the overhead hand, then toward the head, then spontaneously.
4. Time breathing: exhale to push, inhale to pull.
5. Rest with legs long and arms down; sense the diagonal signature.
   return to start
6. Repeat the diagonal push/pull on the second side, using breath to inhibit unnecessary contractions.
7. Imagine exhaling through the fingertips during the push.
8. Rest on back, palms down. return to start
9. Briefly refresh the wide-legged heel push/pull, experimenting with breath timing.

> *A functional goal — connecting this movement to something you actually do in life.*
>
> *The teacher poses a question. Not something to answer, but something to feel into.*
>
> *Noticing how parts of your body are connected — how one movement ripples through.*

WHAT WAS HAPPENING

Negotiation

The question being posed: How does force travel across the body's diagonals?

The functional goal: Clarification of the internal 'X' and its relationship to the vertical axis.

THE PERSON INSIDE

With one foot standing and one arm up, the push travels on a slant. I feel it crossing my chest and heading toward my fingertips. It's a strange, skewed verticality that makes me soften my ribs to let it through.

THE STRIVER

The Shadow is bracing the side of the waist to resist the diagonal twist, but the breath is beginning to wash this away.

Part 4: Pelvic Lift and Pumping

Performing the vertical oscillation with the pelvis lifted, challenging stability and skeletal clarity.

WHAT YOU DID

1. Bend both knees, stand feet, and lift the pelvis to a sustainable height.
2. With pelvis lifted, push and pull the body vertically along the floor.
3. Continue the oscillation while breathing fully; imagine pumping the spine through the shoulders.
4. Increase speed for lightness, then slow down and accentuate the end of the push.
5. Lower pelvis, lengthen legs, and rest. return to start

A functional goal — connecting this movement to something you actually do in life.

The teacher poses a question. Not something to answer, but something to feel into.

An invitation to reduce effort, to find the movement with less force.

WHAT WAS HAPPENING

Negotiation

The question being posed: Can the spine pump through the shoulders while suspended?

The functional goal: Skeletal suspension and mobilization of the upper thoracic spine.

THE PERSON INSIDE

My pelvis is floating in the air, and I am pumping my spine through my shoulders like a turtle. I feel the weight of my head sliding against the floor as my feet drive me up and down. The column is becoming more fluid.

THE STRIVER

The Hoister is clenching the glutes and hamstrings to maintain height, but the oscillation is making that effort feel heavy.

Part 5: Seesaw Breathing

Internalizing the vertical movement through paradoxical and seesaw breathing patterns.

WHAT YOU DID

1. Seesaw breathing: Inhale by drawing in the abdomen and filling the chest high.
2. Seesaw breathing: Inhale by expanding the lower abdomen fully, compressing the chest.
3. Hold the breath and move the air volume up and down between chest and belly like a seesaw.
4. Continue seesaw breathing while inhaling/exhaling, making it soft and natural.
5. Combine heel push/pull with seesaw breathing, exploring which rhythm is most congruent.
6. Rest with knees bent.

> A *functional goal — connecting this movement to something you actually do in life.*
>
> A *moment of sensing — turning attention inward to feel what's actually happening.*
>
> *The teacher poses a question. Not something to answer, but something to feel into.*

WHAT WAS HAPPENING

Negotiation

The question being posed: Can internal pressure move vertically like skeletal force?

The functional goal: Internal softening of the core to allow unobstructed force transmission.

THE PERSON INSIDE

I am moving a ball of air between my chest and my belly. This internal pressure is massaging my spine from the inside. When I combine this with my heels, the movement feels more congruent and less like work.

THE STRIVER

The Striver is getting confused by the paradoxical breathing, which is successfully inhibiting the usual abdominal bracing.

Part 6: Side-Lying and Head Lifting

Translating vertical force into head lifting while lying on the side.

WHAT YOU DID

1. Roll onto the left side, right foot standing, left arm long under the head.
2. Push and pull with the right foot while on the side, sliding the head along the arm.
3. Place right hand on head; at the end of the push, lift the head slightly.
4. Oscillate quickly and lightly on the side, then rest on the back. return to start
5. Repeat the side-lying push/pull and head lift on the right side.

> *A functional goal — connecting this movement to something you actually do in life.*
>
> *Noticing how parts of your body are connected — how one movement ripples through.*
>
> *The teacher poses a question. Not something to answer, but something to feel into.*

WHAT WAS HAPPENING

Integration

The question being posed: Does the vertical push from the foot naturally float the head?

The functional goal: Head lifting as an emergent property of skeletal drive.

THE PERSON INSIDE

On my side, the push from my foot travels all the way to my ear. My head just wants to lift off the arm. It feels light, as if the pressure from the floor is simply carrying it upward.

THE STRIVER

The neck muscles have finally stood down; they are no longer hoisting the head because the skeleton is doing it.

Part 7: Prone Exploration and Integration

Final explorations on the belly and integration into standing and walking.

WHAT YOU DID

1. Roll onto the belly, toes tucked, hands in push-up position.
2. Push with toes and hands to oscillate vertically, lifting the head slightly during the push.
3. Rest on the back. return to start
4. Final heel push/pull with specific breath: exhale/belly out to push, inhale/belly in to pull.
5. Final oscillation with knees bent, exploring different rhythms.
6. Stand and walk, sensing the floor pushing back through the skeleton.

> *A functional goal — connecting this movement to something you actually do in life.*
>
> *Noticing how parts of your body are connected — how one movement ripples through.*
>
> *The teacher poses a question. Not something to answer, but something to feel into.*

WHAT WAS HAPPENING

Integration

The question being posed: How does the floor support me in standing and walking?

The functional goal: Realization of the Vertical Self and efficient gravitational stacking.

THE PERSON INSIDE

I am standing now, and I can feel the floor pushing up through my heels into my crown. As I walk, each step sends a clear signal of support up my spine. I feel tall and suspended between the earth and the sky.

THE STRIVER

The Muscular Hoister is quiet; the bones are now trusted to hold the weight of the world.

The Arc

Every Feldenkrais lesson has a trajectory — from effort to ease, from noise to quiet. Here's how this lesson made that journey.

How the Lesson Washed Away Effort

Cortical noise is reduced by shifting from slow, intentional pushes to rapid, light vibrations that bypass the Muscular Hoister's control. The complexity of the diagonal and breathing variations further distracts the Striver, allowing the Vertical One to emerge.

The Threshold of Quiet

Integration emerges during the side-lying and prone head-lifting sequences, where the student realizes the head can float upward simply because the skeletal column is stacked and the force from the feet has nowhere else to go.

The Negotiation Arc

1. Initial Vertical Oscillation	DOMINATION
2. Heel and Arm Integration	NEGOTIATION
3. Diagonal Force Vectors	NEGOTIATION
4. Pelvic Lift and Pumping	NEGOTIATION
5. Seesaw Breathing	NEGOTIATION
6. Side-Lying and Head Lifting	INTEGRATION
7. Prone Exploration and Integration	INTEGRATION

What the Striver Was Doing

- Localized muscular effort in the lower back and neck to 'hoist' the body upward.
- Bracing the abdominal wall and holding the breath to create a sense of stability.
- Gripping the floor with the toes rather than letting the force transmit through the heels.
- Linear 'trying' to reach the crown of the head by tensing the peripheral muscles.

What the Foundation Discovered

- The emergence of a clear longitudinal force traveling from the feet through the spine to the crown.
- The 'turtle' effect where the spine slides freely through the shoulder structure.
- The head floating into the air as an emergent property of skeletal drive rather than neck effort.
- The sensation of the floor pushing back through the bones during standing and walking.

The Lens: The Vertical Self

How force travels through your skeleton from the floor to your crown. When you're truly vertical, the floor pushes up through your bones all the way to your head — you don't have to hold yourself up.

The Vertical One

The inner being who senses your relationship with gravity. They feel weight dropping through bone, they know when the column is stacked and when it's collapsing. Every movement is received as: *What just happened to my column? Is force transmitting cleanly through my bones, or is something buckling?*

The Shadow: The Muscular Hoister

The one who can't trust the skeleton. They grip the lower back, clench the waist, pull the head up with the neck. They believe that without their effort, everything would collapse. The lesson shows that bones can do what muscles have been forcing.

Next Time

The question this lesson asks doesn't have a final answer. Each time you do it, your nervous system finds a slightly different solution. Here are some things to pay attention to next time:

- Notice the very first moment of sensing — before you move. What do you feel on the floor? What's the shape of your contact?
- Pay attention to the connections. When you move one part, what ripples through to distant parts? Where do you feel unexpected responses?
- Each time you're asked to reduce effort, see how little you can do and still have the movement happen. The answer might surprise you.
- When the teacher poses a question, resist the urge to find an answer. Let the question sit. Your body will answer in its own time.
- Don't rush through the pauses. That's where the real work happens — your nervous system integrating what it just learned.
- Let the imagery work on you. When you imagine a movement, your nervous system rehearses it almost as fully as if you did it. Imagination is movement.

The lesson is a conversation between you and your nervous system. Each time you listen a little more carefully, you hear something new.